

Islamic urban planning

The spread of Islam to parts of Asia, Africa and Europe had an overwhelming impact on urban development. With great diversity in climate, building forms and construction materials, there was at first no uniform style, but the Fatimid period in Egypt (969–1171) saw the emergence of a common architectural vocabulary and town planning.

The main mosque lay at the heart of each town, usually close to the *suq* (market). Nearby was the *madrassa* (school or college), and also the *casbah*, or citadel – the governor's walled palace. Beyond lay residential quarters. In hot and arid climates, residences were designed around courtyards that preserved privacy and kept interiors cool. Doors were located so that they did not overlook others, and windows placed higher than passers-by. Similarly, high windows in buildings did not overlook other dwellings or courtyards. The different quarters were connected by narrow winding streets, with tombs and cemeteries located a short distance beyond the town walls.



The Great Mosque of Kairouan and surroundings, Tunisia